

GROWTH REPORT • TEAM TRAINING COURSE • 6 SESSIONS • 6 CLIENT TYPES • 100+ TOOLS

Growth Strategy Masterclass

Multi-Client Playbook for Tech SaaS, B2B, B2C, E-commerce, Professional Services & Gaming

PREPARED FOR

SuperMem Growth Team

PREPARED BY

SuperMem GrowthOS

STATUS

Internal Training Course

SESSIONS

6

~10 hours total

GROWTH DOMAINS

21

Every dimension
covered

CLIENT TYPES

6

Tailored playbooks

SAAS + AI TOOLS

100+

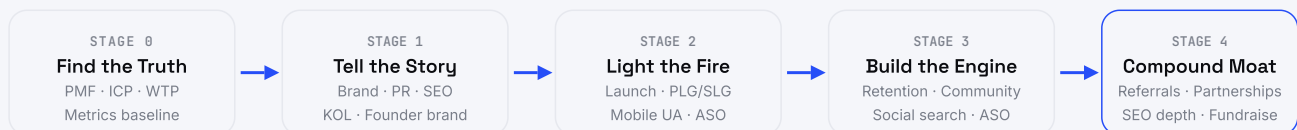
Mapped to each
domain

CASE STUDIES

30+

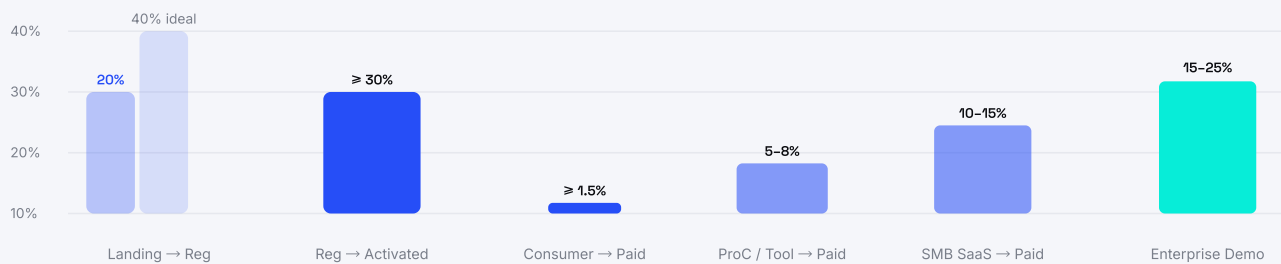
Real company examples

THE FIVE-STAGE GROWTH ARCHITECTURE



Fix retention (Stage 3) before scaling paid acquisition. Never fill a leaky bucket.

MINIMUM FUNNEL CONVERSION BENCHMARKS BEFORE SCALING PAID



Benchmark conversion rates by funnel stage and business model. Do not scale paid acquisition until your funnel hits these thresholds.

Roadmap

Twelve sections — five core sessions, six client-type playbooks, and a master tools appendix.

01

Session 1: Find the Truth

PMF, positioning, pricing, metrics

02

Session 2: Brand Awareness

Founder brand, PR, SEO/GEO, social search, KOL, UGC

03

Session 3: User Acquisition

Launch, PLG/SLG/CLG/MLG, PLS, mobile growth, ASO

04

Session 4: Retention & Monetization

Engagement, mobile monetization, community, partnerships

05

Session 5: Fundraising

Stage criteria, warm intros, narrative

6A

Playbook: Tech SaaS

PLG + PLS

6B

Playbook: B2B

SLG + ABM

6C

Playbook: B2C

PLG + Habit

6D

Playbook: E-commerce

DTC + Retention

6E

Playbook: Professional Services

Referral + Reputation

6F

Playbook: Gaming

D1 Retention + Live Ops



Master Tools Appendix

21 growth domains, canonical tool stack

THE MASTER DOCTRINE

One loop. Dominate it. Every durable company scales through a single dominant growth loop. Your job is to identify which loop and make it irresistible. Everything else — channels, tools, campaigns — is support structure. Before any engagement, run three filters: (1) What is the ONE unfair advantage? (2) Which 2–3 channels match that advantage? (3) Is the conversion funnel healthy enough to justify spending on acquisition?

Find the Truth

Before any marketing or growth tactic, you need to know whether the product actually delivers value, for whom, at what price. Sessions that skip this stage build growth machines that amplify the wrong product to the wrong people.

1.1 PMF & User Research

"Product market fit is something where you absolutely know it when you see it. Therefore if you don't absolutely know it, you don't have it."

— MATT MACINNIS

PMF is not a binary switch. It is a spectrum that moves through four levels:

LEVEL 1

Problem Fit — Real people have the problem you're solving. You've confirmed demand without building anything.

LEVEL 2

Solution Fit — Your solution solves the problem. Users who try it get value and say so.

LEVEL 3

Product Fit — Your product reliably delivers that solution at scale. Onboarding works. Retention is positive.

LEVEL 4

Market Fit — A large enough segment buys repeatedly. CAC is recoverable. NRR exceeds 100%. The machine works.

THE SEAN ELLIS TEST

Survey active users: "How would you feel if you could no longer use this product?" If **<40% answer "Very disappointed"**, you do not have PMF. Run by segment — you may have PMF with one ICP but not another. HeyGen scored >40% among enterprise comms teams but not among casual video creators.

PMF LOSS SIGNALS — WATCH FOR THESE

- Rising churn despite growing acquisition — the bucket leaks faster than you fill it
- Support tickets cluster around the same 2–3 failure points — onboarding is broken
- NPS is flat or declining quarter-over-quarter despite product updates
- Sales cycle extends — buyers need more convincing, which means value proposition is unclear
- Users who were "activated" in month 1 don't return in month 3

CASE STUDY

HeyGen: Narrowing ICP to Find PMF

HeyGen launched as an AI video creation tool for "anyone who makes videos." They had thousands of users but inconsistent retention. The breakthrough came when they ran Sean Ellis tests segmented by use case. Enterprise comms teams — those creating multilingual training and marketing videos — scored 67% "Very disappointed." Casual creators scored 18%. HeyGen rebuilt messaging and onboarding exclusively around the enterprise use case, tripling retention among the segment that mattered. By 2024 they were at \$35M ARR.

Lesson: Broad ICP = diluted value. Narrow until the Sean Ellis score exceeds 40% in a segment large enough to build a business on.

USER INTERVIEW SOP

5-STEP INTERVIEW PROTOCOL

1. **Recruit the right people** — current users, lapsed users, and non-users who match your ICP. Never friends.
2. **Start with context, not product** — "Walk me through the last time you dealt with [problem]." You want to understand their world before showing yours.
3. **Probe the status quo** — "What do you do today when this happens? What do you hate about it?"
4. **Test willingness to pay (WTP)** — Van Westendorp price sensitivity meter: too cheap / bargain / getting expensive / too expensive. You want the range between "bargain" and "getting expensive."
5. **Synthesize across 8–10 interviews** — look for pattern convergence in Dovetail or Notion, not individual outliers.

FUNCTION	TOOLS	BEST FOR
Survey & WTP testing	Typeform, Tally, SurveyMonkey	Quantitative signal at scale
User interview	Lookback, UserTesting, Maze	Moderated + unmoderated sessions
Interview recording	Otter.ai, Granola, Fireflies.ai	Transcription + AI summaries
Research synthesis	Dovetail, Notion AI	Theme extraction across interviews
PMF analytics	Mixpanel, PostHog	Retention cohort analysis
AI synthesis	Claude	Pattern recognition across 20+ transcripts

1.2 Positioning & Pricing

"Weak positioning hurts you in the early stages of pipeline — people don't get what you are."

— APRIL DUNFORD

Positioning answers one question in the buyer's mind: *why this, instead of that?* Most startups describe what their product does (features). April Dunford's framework forces you to describe what makes it *uniquely better for a specific buyer vs. a specific alternative*.

APRIL DUNFORD'S 5-COMPONENT POSITIONING FRAMEWORK

1. **Competitive alternatives** — what would buyers do if your product didn't exist? (Excel, hiring someone, a competitor, doing nothing)
2. **Unique attributes** — what do you have that alternatives don't?
3. **Value (not features)** — what value do those attributes unlock for the buyer?
4. **Segmentation** — who cares most about that specific value? That's your best-fit ICP.
5. **Market category** — what frame do you put around yourself? The wrong category makes you look expensive or irrelevant.

CASE STUDY

Supabase: Positioning Against Firebase

Firebase was the dominant backend-as-a-service for developers. Supabase positioned not as "another BaaS" but as "the open-source Firebase alternative." Their tagline: "Build in a weekend. Scale to millions." This single line collapsed the complexity objection (scale is hard) while owning the speed advantage (weekend = fast). By naming the competitor in their positioning, they captured every developer searching for "Firebase alternative" on Google — and converted them with open-source credibility.

Lesson: Naming your competitive alternative in positioning is not weakness — it's the fastest path to being understood by the right buyer.

PRICING PRINCIPLES

PRINCIPLE 1

Price is a value signal. Pricing too low communicates low quality. Price at what the segment believes the value is worth, not at cost + margin.

PRINCIPLE 2

Freemium gates the wrong thing. Most teams gate premium features. Masters gate *scale* — free up to X, paid above X. This converts power users, not casual browsers.

PRINCIPLE 3

Self-serve ceiling exists. Deals above \$25–50K ACV almost always need a human in the loop. Build

PRINCIPLE 4

Reverse trial works. Give users the paid tier free for 14 days, then downgrade. Converts 2–3x better

the PLS motion (product-led sales) before you hit the ceiling.

than free tier → upgrade, because loss aversion beats feature discovery.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
Competitive intelligence	Klue, Crayon, Kompyte, Similarweb
Win/loss analysis	Gong, Chorus (ZoomInfo)
Pricing analytics	ProfitWell (Paddle), Baremetrics, ChartMogul
A/B test pricing pages	Optimizely, LaunchDarkly
Market & ICP research	Perplexity, Claude, G2, Capterra

1.3 Metrics & Benchmarks

The North Star metric is the one number that best captures how much value you're delivering. Everything else is a leading or lagging indicator of it.

RETENTION CURVE SHAPE — WHAT EACH MEANS



Flattening retention = defensible moat. If your D30 approaches D7, you have strong product stickiness.

NORTH STAR BY BUSINESS MODEL	METRIC	SECONDARY KPIS
SaaS / PLG	Weekly Active Users reaching Aha Moment	Activation rate, NRR, PQL conversion
B2B Enterprise	ARR / Net Revenue Retention	Win rate, ACV, time-to-close
Consumer app	DAU / D30 retention	DAU:MAU ratio, K-factor, LTV:CAC
E-commerce	Revenue per customer (LTV)	Repeat purchase rate, email revenue %, ROAS
Mobile game	D7 retention	ARPPDAU, session length, K-factor

NORTH STAR BY BUSINESS MODEL	METRIC	SECONDARY KPIS
Marketplace	GMV or Liquidity rate	Repeat take rate, supply/demand balance

FUNCTION	TOOLS
Product analytics	Mixpanel, Amplitude, PostHog, Heap
Web analytics	GA4, Plausible, Fathom
CDP / data pipeline	Segment, RudderStack, mParticle
BI / dashboards	Looker, Metabase, Tableau, Sigma
AI analytics	ThoughtSpot, Julius AI
Revenue analytics	Baremetrics, ChartMogul, ProfitWell

[Diagnose your PMF ↗](#)

Tell the Story — Brand & Awareness

Brand is not a logo. It is a coherent promise that makes one type of person feel seen and makes everyone else self-select out. The best brands in tech aren't neutral — they have a point of view that attracts passionate advocates and repels the wrong buyers.

2.1 Founder Brand

"Attention is the ultimate currency. Authenticity beats polish. Founders must own their narrative."

— LULU CHENG MESERVEY

A founder with 100K followers in the right niche is worth more than \$200K in ad spend. Founder brand is a compounding distribution asset — every post extends reach for free, builds trust faster than any ad, and creates inbound that no SDR can replicate.

PLATFORM PLAYBOOKS

LINKEDIN

Tone: Professional insight with personality. **What works:** contrarian takes on industry norms, process breakdowns ("here's how we closed our Series A"), specific numbers ("we went from 0 to 10K users in 8 weeks — here's what actually drove it"). **Cadence:** 3–4 posts/week. DM reply rate: 10–15%.

TWITTER / X

Tone: Direct, sharp, opinionated. **What works:** threads with 10–15 specific lessons, hot takes on product, live build-in-public updates. **Cadence:** 1–2 posts/day. First 60 seconds after posting determine algorithmic reach — reply to every early comment.

XHS (小红书)

Tone: Lifestyle + insight hybrid. **What works:** "a day in the life of a founder" formats, product use in real-life contexts, emotional storytelling with product integration. **Cadence:** 4–5 posts/week. Discovery is keyword-driven — use exact-match keyword phrases in first line.

HOOK BANK

Start with: "Most [category] advice is wrong. Here's what actually works." / "I spent \$200K on ads before I learned this one thing." / "Nobody talks about this but..." / "After [X] years, here's the uncomfortable truth." / "We [achieved result]. Here's the system."

CASE STUDY

Gong: Category Creation Through Thought Leadership

Gong's CEO Amit Bendov didn't just sell conversation intelligence — he created the category of "Revenue Intelligence." Every LinkedIn post, every webinar, every piece of content was positioned around this new frame. Their "State of Revenue Intelligence" annual report became industry-required reading, cited by VCs and sales leaders. They controlled the category definition, so any competitor was automatically "a Gong alternative." This positioning contributed to a \$7.25B valuation.

Lesson: The company that names the category wins the category. Create the frame, then own it through consistent thought leadership.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
LinkedIn growth & scheduling	Taplio, Shield Analytics, LinkedIn Sales Navigator
Twitter / X growth	Hypefury, Typefully, Black Magic
Multi-platform scheduling	Buffer, Later, Hootsuite, Metricool
AI content drafting	Claude, Jasper, Writer.com, Copy.ai
Analytics	Sprout Social, Iconosquare

2.2 Storytelling & PR

"Never fight a story with a statistic. Always fight story with story."

— LULU CHENG MESERVEY

THE GO DIRECT FRAMEWORK

Traditional PR waits for media coverage. Go Direct means the company publishes its own narrative through owned channels before, during, and after any media coverage. When journalists do write about you, they pull from your framing.

4 PR NARRATIVE STRUCTURES

- 1. Origin story** — "We built this because we faced the problem ourselves." Authenticity + urgency. (Airbnb: "We rented air mattresses to pay rent and accidentally built a company.")
- 2. Foil story** — "The way everyone does this is wrong, and here's why." Creates tension, positions you as the smart alternative. (Notion: "Spreadsheets aren't databases. Docs aren't wikis. We're both.")
- 3. Movement story** — "We're not selling a product, we're starting a movement." Bigger than you. (Patagonia: "We're in business to save our home planet.")
- 4. Data story** — "Here's a trend only we can see because of our data." Credibility + exclusivity. (Gong's sales data reports, Stripe's developer economy reports.)

CASE STUDY

Airbnb: Storytelling as Survival

During COVID, Airbnb hosts were facing financial ruin. Instead of a corporate press release, Airbnb CEO Brian Chesky wrote an open letter to employees when they had to lay off 25% of the team — with radical transparency about severance, healthcare, and why it happened. The letter went viral. Journalists wrote about it as an example of exceptional leadership. During one of the worst crises in travel history, Airbnb built more brand trust than most companies do in a decade. Their IPO in December 2020 — despite \$700M losses — was oversubscribed.

Lesson: Authentic storytelling in a crisis builds more trust than a polished statement. The vulnerability is the story.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
PR / media database	Muck Rack, Cision, Meltwater
Press distribution	PR Newswire, PRWeb, Business Wire
Media monitoring	Mention, Brand24, Google Alerts
AI-assisted PR	Propel (AI PR platform), Onclusive

2.3 SEO & GEO (AI Search Optimization)

SEO IN 2025: TWO PARALLEL ENGINES

Traditional SEO (Google Search) still drives enormous volume, but GEO — Generative Engine Optimization — is rapidly becoming a parallel channel. ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Claude synthesize answers from web content. Being cited in those answers requires different tactics than ranking in Google.

TRADITIONAL SEO

Priority keywords: Bottom-of-funnel first ("best CRM for startups"). **Content type:** Comparison pages, alternative pages, how-to guides. **Authority building:** Backlinks from domain-relevant sites. **Case:** HubSpot's 500+ comparison pages drive 30% of their trial signups.

GEO (AI SEARCH)

What works: Original data and research (AI cites sources). Comprehensive definitional articles. FAQ content that answers exactly what AI models are asked. **Format:** Clear headings, structured data. **Monitoring:** Profound, Otterly.ai — track when AI answers cite your domain.

DOMAIN HACKS

SmallPDF bought expired high-authority domains and redirected 301s to their content. This transferred decades of domain authority overnight. Works for any content-heavy product. Investment:

TOPICAL AUTHORITY

Don't scatter content across 50 topics. Pick 3–5 core topics and dominate them. Notion owns "project management templates," "wiki software,"

\$2–20K. Return: equivalent to 2 years of organic link building.

and "team collaboration" as topic clusters. Google now rewards clusters over individual articles.

CASE STUDY

HubSpot: The Content Machine That Built a \$20B Company

HubSpot's content strategy started in 2006 — years before "content marketing" was a term. They published educational content on inbound marketing (a term they coined), building topical authority around their product category. By the time competitors arrived, HubSpot owned thousands of keywords across the marketing funnel. Today, their blog receives 7M+ monthly visits. Most visitors are in problem-awareness mode — perfect for building brand trust before they consider buying. HubSpot's organic search alone is valued at \$500M+ in equivalent paid traffic.

Lesson: The earlier you start building topical authority, the more compounding returns you accumulate. SEO is a content endowment, not a campaign.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
SEO research	Ahrefs, SEMrush, Moz
Content optimization	Surfer SEO, Clearscope, MarketMuse, Frase
Technical SEO	Screaming Frog, Sitebulb
GEO monitoring	Profound, Otterly.ai, AI Search Monitor
CMS / publishing	WordPress, Webflow, Contentful
AI writing	Claude, Jasper, Writer.com

2.4 Social Search (TikTok / Instagram as Search Engine)

Gen Z uses TikTok before Google for recommendations, how-tos, and product discovery. For consumer products, social search is now the primary discovery channel for the 18–34 demographic.

5-DIMENSION VIABILITY AUDIT

Before investing in social search for a client: (1) Search volume — do people actually search this topic on TikTok? (2) Content competition — how many creators are in this niche? (3) Creator saturation — are there already 100+ creators with 100K+ followers? (4) Monetization fit — does the niche attract buyers, not just browsers? (5) Brand safety — can you show up authentically without brand risk?

CASE STUDY

Duolingo: The Brand That Learned to Troll Itself

Duolingo's TikTok strategy is case-study-famous. Their green owl mascot "Duo" was reframed as a passive-aggressive stalker reminding users to practice. The account accumulated 7M+ followers not through product demos but through absurdist humor that went viral. Crucially, every video still embedded a behavioral nudge — "you haven't practiced today." The result: TikTok drove a 50%+ increase in app downloads during their peak viral moments, all at zero paid media cost.

Lesson: On TikTok, entertainment and product message must coexist. Find the tension or humor in your product's core mechanic and dramatize it.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
TikTok analytics	Pentos, Analisa.io, TikTok Analytics (native)
Instagram analytics	Iconosquare, Social Blade
Video editing	CapCut, DaVinci Resolve, Adobe Rush
AI video / avatar	HeyGen, Synthesia, Descript
Scheduling	Later, Planoly, TikTok Scheduler

2.5 KOL & Influencer Marketing

PLATFORM PRICE BENCHMARKS (2025)

Use these as anchors when negotiating. Always open at 30% of quoted price and run 4–5 rounds.

PLATFORM	TIER	FOLLOWER RANGE	MARKET PRICE	OPEN AT
Twitter / X	Micro	10K–100K	\$200–\$2K/post	\$60–\$600
Twitter / X	Macro	500K+	\$5K–\$30K/post	\$1.5K–\$9K
YouTube	Mid-tier	100K–500K	\$3K–\$15K/video	\$900–\$4.5K
YouTube	Macro	1M+	\$20K–\$100K/video	\$6K–\$30K
TikTok	Micro	50K–500K	\$500–\$5K/video	\$150–\$1.5K
Instagram	Mid-tier	100K–1M	\$2K–\$20K/post	\$600–\$6K
LinkedIn	Thought leader	50K+	\$3K–\$25K/post	\$900–\$7.5K

RELATIVE PRICE CEILING BY PLATFORM – TOP TIER, PER POST/VIDEO

YouTube (macro)		up to \$100K
Twitter/X (macro)		up to \$30K
LinkedIn (thought leader)		up to \$25K
Instagram (mid-tier)		up to \$20K
TikTok (micro)		up to \$5K

THE THREE-ACTION PACKAGE

Never buy a single post. Always bundle: **1 main post + 1 story/reel repost + 1 comment engagement**. This triples exposure at marginal cost. The comment from the creator makes your brand visible to their audience a second time — in a context that looks organic.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
KOL discovery	Modash, Upfluence, HYPR, AspireIQ
Campaign management	Grin, Creator.co, Traackr
Performance tracking	Magic Links, Refersion
Outreach at scale	Apollo.io, Instantly.ai

2.6 Social Content & UGC

User-generated content converts 4× better than brand-created content because it carries social proof. The goal is to create systems that generate UGC consistently, not wait for it to happen.

UGC MATRIX

Type A — Testimonial videos: \$150–\$400/piece. Highest trust signal. **Type B — Product demos:** \$80–\$200/piece. Best for conversion. **Type C — Lifestyle / use-case:** \$50–\$150/piece. Best for awareness. Brief must specify exact hook, product moment, and CTA.

REDDIT STRATEGY

Reddit resists overt marketing but rewards authenticity. Best approach: Hire 2–3 community members as paid moderators who surface your product naturally in relevant threads. Never pay for posts. Never post from brand accounts. Track subreddits where your ICP lives. Respond to problems with genuine help, product second.

VIRAL LOOP DESIGN

The mechanic: sharing should be a natural extension of the core product action. **Loom:** sending a video IS sharing. **Wordle:** sharing your

PHANTOM BUSTER

Automate LinkedIn engagement sequences: (1) visit profile, (2) connect with personalized note, (3) follow up with value-add message. 8–12%

grid IS the game. **Figma:** collaborating IS sharing. Design virality into the product action, not as an afterthought "Share" button.

connection acceptance on targeted lists. Never use generic templates — personalize at the company-signal level using Clay enrichment.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
UGC collection	Yotpo, Bazaarvoice, Loox, Okendo
Social proof & reviews	Trustpilot, G2, Capterra, Stamped.io
Content creation	Canva, Adobe Express, Figma
Automation	Phantombuster, Zapier, Make

Craft Brand Narrative ↗

Light the Fire — User Acquisition

Acquisition is only valuable if the users you bring in stay. Before scaling any channel, confirm your activation and D7 retention hit benchmarks. Otherwise you're accelerating churn, not growth.

3.1 Launch Playbook

A launch is not a day — it's a 6-week campaign with the "launch day" in the middle. The pre-launch builds pressure; the post-launch converts momentum into users and press.

6-WEEK LAUNCH SOP

WEEKS -6 TO -4

Build the audience: Founder posts daily on target platforms. Identify and brief 10–20 KOLs. Create waitlist with referral mechanic (GrowSurf, Viral Loops). Seed private communities (Slack groups, Discord servers) with early access offer.

WEEKS -3 TO -2

Warm the machine: Ship teaser content (behind-the-scenes, problems-we-solve series). Send KOL assets and brief. Post Product Hunt "upcoming" page. Collect testimonials from beta users. Prepare PR pitch for 5 target journalists.

LAUNCH WEEK

5-day drop structure (Supabase model): Day 1: flagship feature. Day 2: integration or partnership. Day 3: customer story. Day 4: data / research release. Day 5: community event or AMA. Each day is its own announcement.

WEEKS +1 TO +2

Convert the momentum: Follow up with all waitlist signups within 24h. Run retargeting ads to site visitors from launch week. Publish launch retrospective (transparency builds trust). Submit to Product Hunt if not already done.

PRODUCT HUNT STRATEGY

PH FULL STRATEGY

Hunter selection: Find a hunter with 3K+ followers and past Top 5 launches. DM them 4 weeks out.

Comment velocity: First 2 hours are critical. Have 50+ supporters lined up to comment (not vote) immediately at 12:01am PT. **KOL coordination:** Ask each KOL to post their Product Hunt link to their audience at launch time. **Timing:** Tuesday–Thursday launches outperform Monday and Friday. Launch at 12:01am PT.

CASE STUDY

Linear: The Invite-Only Launch That Created FOMO

Linear launched in 2020 with a tiny team and zero paid marketing. They made the product invite-only — not as a genuine technical constraint but as a positioning move. The scarcity created organic buzz on Twitter among developers. Early access felt like joining an exclusive club. Their design-forward approach and keyboard-first product generated obsessive word-of-mouth. The waitlist grew to 30,000+ before public launch. By keeping the product hard to access, they turned the launch itself into marketing. Linear was valued at \$400M in their 2022 funding round.

Lesson: Artificial scarcity converts curious observers into active advocates. The waitlist is not just a queue — it's your first community.

CASE STUDY

Superhuman: Qualification as Brand Signal

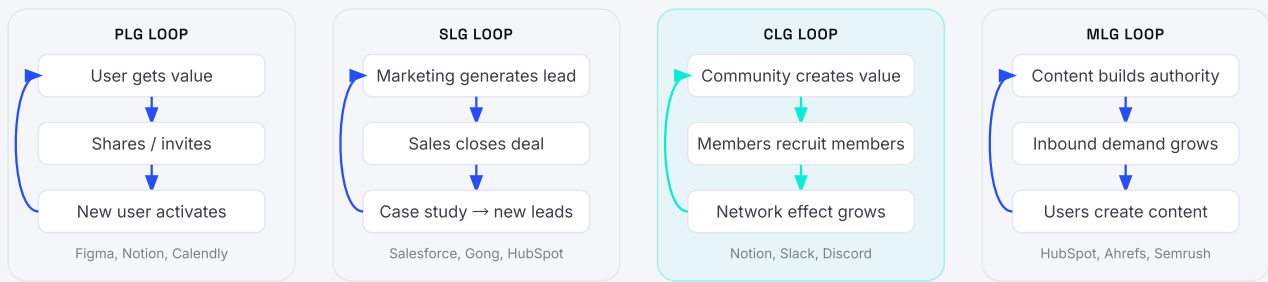
Superhuman's waitlist didn't just collect emails — it asked qualifying questions: "What email client do you use? How many emails do you send per day? How would you rate your inbox management?" Two effects: (1) They collected ICP data before launch. (2) The qualification process itself made Superhuman feel premium. People who passed felt like they had earned access. At \$30/month for an email app, the psychological framing of earned access justified the price. Waitlist: 275,000 people at peak.

Lesson: The application process IS the brand experience. Qualification communicates exclusivity better than any copywriting.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
Landing page	Carrd, Webflow, Framer
Waitlist + referral	Viral Loops, GrowSurf, ReferralHero
Email capture	Loops.so, Mailchimp, ConvertKit
Launch analytics	Mixpanel, PostHog, Hotjar
Coordinated posting	Buffer, Hypefury

3.2 Growth Engines: PLG / SLG / CLG / MLG

GROWTH LOOP TYPES — HOW EACH COMPOUNDS



PLG and CLG produce compounding returns. SLG and MLG require ongoing investment but are more predictable.

CASE STUDY

Notion: PLG to CLG to Enterprise — The Full Journey

Notion launched in 2018 with a PLG motion: free tier, personal use, beautiful product. The "personal to team" expansion was engineered into the product — you create something great, want to share it with a colleague, and suddenly a team workspace gets created. CLG amplified this: Notion's ambassador program seeded college campuses with power users who became evangelists. By 2021, bottoms-up adoption had reached enterprise decision-makers who were already using Notion personally.

Enterprise sales was almost pulling, not pushing. Notion reached \$10B valuation without a traditional sales-led motion until well after their CLG had saturated the market.

Lesson: PLG seeds the individual. CLG builds the social proof. Enterprise sales harvests the installed base. The sequence matters.

3.3 Product-Led Sales (PLS)

"Product-led sales converts the usage that you've generated via self-serve into a sales opportunity and attaches a salesperson to close a much larger contract."

— ELENA VERNA

PQL VS PQA

PQL (Product Qualified Lead): An individual user showing high-intent behavior — invited 5+ teammates, exported data 3+ times, hit usage ceiling, opened pricing page.

PQA (Product Qualified Account): A company with 3+ active users from the same domain, suggesting organic team adoption without a sales conversation.

HIGH-INTENT SIGNAL FRAMEWORK

SIGNAL	INTENT LEVEL	RESPONSE
Opened pricing page 3+ times	Very High	SDR outreach within 24h

SIGNAL	INTENT LEVEL	RESPONSE
Invited 5+ teammates	High	Automated expansion email + SDR follow-up
Hit free tier limit	High	In-app upgrade prompt + trial offer
3+ users from same domain	Medium-High	PQA alert → Account Executive assigned
Used API / integration	Medium	Developer-specific nurture sequence
Completed onboarding checklist	Medium	Success check-in email at Day 7

FUNCTION	TOOLS
PQL scoring	Pendo, MadKudu, Endgame, Correlated
Usage-to-CRM signals	Amplitude / Mixpanel → Salesforce integration
CRM	Salesforce, HubSpot
Conversation intelligence	Gong, Chorus
Outreach automation	Outreach, Salesloft, Apollo.io
AI SDR / BDR	11x, Artisan, Regie.ai, Orum

3.4 Mobile App Growth

Mobile app growth follows a strict prerequisite chain: ASO first (optimize the listing) → then paid UA → then retention optimization. Paying for installs before the listing is optimized is burning money. Paying for installs before D7 retention is proven is building a leaky bucket.

8-WEEK MOBILE LAUNCH TIMELINE

WEEKS 1-2

ASO audit: optimize title, subtitle, keywords, screenshots, and icon. Submit to TestFlight / closed beta. Collect 50+ reviews before launch to prime algorithm.

WEEKS 3-4

Soft launch in 2-3 lower-CPM markets (e.g. Philippines, South Africa). Optimize onboarding until D1 ≥ 30%. Fix crashes. Tune push notification permissions prompt placement.

WEEKS 5-6

Begin Apple Search Ads (branded + category keywords). Layer in creator UGC briefs. Set up Branch deep links for social ads → app store.

WEEKS 7-8

Full paid UA launch: scale Apple Search Ads, Google UAC, Meta. A/B test creatives (kill at

\$50 spend, scale winners). Apply for featuring with platform team.

CASE STUDY

Calm: Scaling to \$2B Without a Traditional Sales Team

Calm grew to 100M+ downloads primarily through three channels. First, Apple Health integration — Calm appeared in Apple's recommended wellness apps, giving them zero-cost distribution inside iOS. Second, ASO dominance: they owned "meditation," "sleep sounds," and "anxiety relief" on both App Stores through relentless keyword optimization and 500K+ 5-star reviews. Third, celebrity voice content (Matthew McConaughey, Harry Styles narrating sleep stories) created PR hooks that traditional wellness apps couldn't afford to match. Each celebrity signing generated earned media worth 10× the talent cost.

Lesson: Platform partnerships (Apple Health) provide distribution that no ad budget can replicate. Get native to the platform before paying for acquisition.

3.5 App Store Optimization (ASO)

ELEMENT	IOS	ANDROID	WHAT MOVES THE NEEDLE
Title	30 chars	50 chars	Include primary keyword naturally. Do not keyword-stuff.
Subtitle / Short desc	30 chars	80 chars	Secondary keyword cluster + value proposition
Keyword field (iOS)	100 chars	N/A	No spaces before commas. Use competitors' names. No duplication with title.
Screenshots	First 3 shown in search	First 3 shown	First screenshot must show core action or value, not a splash screen
Icon	No text	No text	Single dominant color, single recognizable shape. Test in grayscale.
Ratings	Displayed in search	Displayed	>4.4 required to not hurt CTR. Prompt after moment of delight, not on open.
Category	2 categories	1 category	Pick secondary category with less competition if primary is saturated

FUNCTION	TOOLS
ASO research	Sensor Tower, AppTweak, MobileAction, AppFollow
A/B testing storelisting	StoreMaven, SplitMetrics, Google Play Experiments
Reviews management	AppFollow, Apptentive
Localization	Lokalise, Phrase

[Find Your Growth Strategy ↗](#)

Build the Engine — Retention & Monetization

Retention is the truth test of whether your product creates value. All acquisition, all brand, all launch effort only compounds if users come back.

"Retention. If you create value, they will come back. If they're not coming back, you're not creating value."

— URI LEVINE, CO-FOUNDER OF WAZE

4.1 Retention & Engagement

THE AHA MOMENT

The Aha Moment is the first time a new user experiences the core value of your product. Everything in onboarding should be engineered to deliver this moment as fast as possible.

PRODUCT	AHA MOMENT	TIME TO AHA	HOW THEY ENGINEER IT
Slack	Send first message in a real channel	< 5 min	Pre-populates workspace with sample channels and teammate profiles
Duolingo	Complete first lesson with correct answers	< 3 min	First lesson is deliberately easy. Dopamine hit on completion is the hook.
Figma	Collaborate with a teammate on a design in real time	< 10 min	Starter templates + automatic "invite collaborator" prompt
Notion	Transform a blank page into a structured workspace	< 15 min	New user gets a template gallery on first open — skips the blank page problem
Dropbox	See a file appear on both devices	< 5 min	Onboarding step: install desktop app + drag one file = magic

HABIT FORMATION FRAMEWORK

Trigger (external or internal cue) → **Routine** (the product action) → **Reward** (the value delivered).

Duolingo's streak is a trigger. The lesson is the routine. The owl celebration is the reward. When users miss a day, the streak anxiety becomes an internal trigger. Design all three components intentionally.

CASE STUDY

Spotify Discover Weekly: Personalization as Retention

Spotify had a retention problem in 2014 — users would listen for a while, then churn to YouTube or Pandora. Discover Weekly, launched in 2015, changed this. Every Monday, a playlist of 30 songs was generated specifically for each user based on listening history. The personalization was so good that users felt the product "knew them." More importantly, it gave users a reason to open Spotify every single Monday — a weekly engagement ritual. First month: 1.7M shares. After 10 weeks: 40M people had listened. Discover Weekly is now cited as the key inflection point in Spotify's retention and subscriber conversion.

Lesson: A personalized recurring ritual (weekly, daily, monthly) creates behavioral grooves that competitors cannot replicate without your data.

MOUNTING LOSS DESIGN

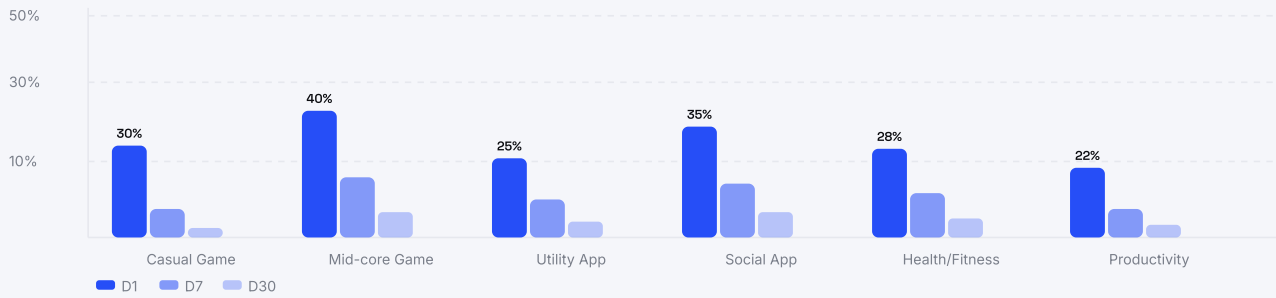
THE PRINCIPLE

"The product should get better the more you use it, and you'll have more to lose by leaving it." — Sarah Tavel. Examples: Notion (all your work is there), Spotify (music taste is mapped), Strava (workout history, friend network). Design features that accumulate value over time so the switching cost grows with usage.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
Behavioral analytics	Mixpanel, Amplitude, FullStory, Heap
Session recording	FullStory, Hotjar, Microsoft Clarity
In-app onboarding	Appcues, Intercom, Chameleon, Userpilot
Email automation	Customer.io, Braze, ActiveCampaign, Loops.so
AI retention	Gainsight, ChurnZero, Totango

4.2 Mobile Retention & Monetization

MOBILE RETENTION BENCHMARKS BY APP CATEGORY



Industry benchmark retention rates by app category. If your app falls below D7 benchmark, fix retention before scaling paid UA.

PAYWALL & SUBSCRIPTION PRINCIPLES

PAYWALL PLACEMENT

Show the paywall after the user has experienced value — not at signup, not during onboarding. Duolingo waits until users fail a lesson to show the "no ads + unlimited lives" offer. The context creates desire.

ANNUAL VS MONTHLY

Annual plans should be positioned as the "smart choice" default, not the hidden option. Pricing anchoring: show monthly price first (\$29/mo), then reveal annual (\$159/yr = "Save 54%"). The comparison does the selling.

TRIAL DESIGN

7-day trials convert better than 14-day trials for impulse-buy products. Reverse trials (give premium free, downgrade to free) convert 2–3× better than upgrade from free. Users have to give something up, which activates loss aversion.

DUNNING RECOVERY

Failed payment sequence: Day 0 in-app banner, Day 3 email ("Update payment to save your data"), Day 7 email with offer ("6 months free if you stay"), Day 14 final. 15–30% of churned revenue recoverable with well-timed dunning.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
Subscription management	RevenueCat, Adapty, Apphud
Paywall A/B testing	RevenueCat Experiments, Adapty Paywall Builder
Push & engagement	Braze, OneSignal, CleverTap
Review management	AppFollow, Apptentive

4.3 Community & Ecosystem

CASE STUDY

Notion's 50% Ambassador Model

Notion created one of the most effective ambassador programs in tech history. Campus ambassadors received 50% of their referrals' first-year revenue. This wasn't charity — it was an acquisition channel

with measurable CAC. Ambassadors were incentivized to be genuine advocates because their income depended on referred users actually staying. The program seeded Notion into over 500 universities before the company had a formal enterprise sales team. By the time enterprise buyers encountered Notion, their employees were already using it personally — making the sales conversation "we need the enterprise plan" rather than "let me convince you to try this."

Lesson: Revenue-sharing with ambassadors converts them from promoters to invested partners. The economics align when their earnings depend on retention, not just signups.

4.4 Partnerships & BD

5 BD ANTI-PATTERNS TO AVOID

- 1. **Partnership as press release.** Announce a partnership with no activation plan. Users never experience it. Lasts 6 weeks then dies.
- 2. **Equal effort assumption.** Assuming the larger partner will promote as hard as you will. They won't. You need to run the activation.
- 3. **Integration without adoption.** Building a Zapier integration that 12 people use. Integrations need their own go-to-market.
- 4. **VC as BD shortcut.** Asking investors for intros before you have a clear ask, a working product, and proof of value. Burns the intro.
- 5. **Co-marketing with misaligned ICP.** Partnering with a company that reaches a totally different buyer. All effort, no conversion.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
Partner management	PartnerStack, Impact, Crossbeam, Reveal
Affiliate programs	Impact, ShareASale, CJ Affiliate
Community platforms	Circle, Discord, Slack, Discourse
Events	Bevy, Hopin, Lu.ma
Community analytics	Orbit, Common Room

Free Consultation with Growth Expert ↗

Compound the Moat — Fundraising

Fundraising is a distribution problem, not a pitch problem. The company that gets funded is the one that makes investors feel they'll miss out if they pass — not the one with the most polished deck.

STAGE CRITERIA — WHAT INVESTORS ACTUALLY NEED TO SEE

STAGE	CHECK SIZE	MUST HAVE	NICE TO HAVE
Pre-seed	\$250K–\$2M	Founder-market fit, problem evidence, MVP or mockup	Early users, any revenue
Seed	\$2M–\$5M	PMF signal, 10–50 paying customers, clear ICP	MoM growth >15%, NRR >100%
Series A	\$8M–\$20M	Repeatable acquisition channel, \$1M+ ARR, <12mo CAC payback	NRR >120%, expansion motion
Series B	\$20M–\$60M	Proven sales org, \$5M+ ARR growing >100% YoY, clear \$1B+ market	International signal, enterprise logo

WARM INTRO STRATEGY

Cold inbound to VCs has a <1% meeting rate. Warm intros via mutual portfolio founders convert at 30–50%. The fastest path: identify which VCs have invested in companies that use your product → ask those founders for an intro → arrive with social proof already built in.

CASE STUDY

Stripe: Selling the Inevitability Narrative

Stripe's 2010 pitch to investors wasn't "we're building a payment API." It was "the internet is going to eat commerce and no one has built the payment infrastructure for that world." Patrick Collison sold the inevitability of the market, not the features of the product. Investors who passed weren't saying no to Stripe — they were betting against the internet eating commerce. That frame made the pass feel much riskier than the investment. Stripe closed their seed round at a \$20M valuation and are now valued at \$65B+.

Lesson: The best pitches make investors feel that passing is the risk, not investing. Sell the inevitability of the world you're building for, not the product you have today.

FUNCTION	TOOLS
Investor CRM	Affinity, DealCloud, Folk
Data room	Docsend, Notion, Google Drive
Pitch deck	Pitch, Beautiful.ai, Canva
Cap table	Carta, Pulley
Investor research	Crunchbase, PitchBook

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Client Playbooks — Master vs. Mediocre

The difference between a good growth practitioner and a great one is not knowledge of frameworks — it's the specific moves, instincts, and non-obvious choices that separate dominant companies from the average. This session is about those moves.

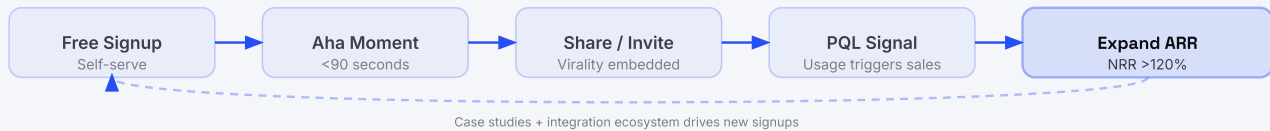
HOW TO USE THIS SECTION

Each playbook covers: (1) The primary growth loop, (2) Master vs. Mediocre comparison — the exact behaviors that separate top-quartile companies from average ones, (3) 6 pro tips that masters use, (4) Key metrics with benchmarks, and (5) A deep case study breakdown.

Tech SaaS

PLG + PLS

TECH SAAS PRIMARY GROWTH LOOP



KEY DIFFERENTIATOR – NET REVENUE RETENTION



AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Aha Moment	Guided feature tour. User knows what exists but hasn't experienced value. Time-to-Aha: 5–15 minutes or never.	Eliminates every step between signup and first value. Notion auto-populates a workspace. Calendly pre-fills times. Target <90 seconds. Every extra click tested and removed.
Virality Mechanics	"Share with a friend" button buried in settings. Referrals only when users remember to share.	Virality in core product action. Loom watermark on every video. Figma: "invite collaborator" required to work together. Calendly: "Scheduling powered by Calendly" on every booking. Every share is passive marketing.
PLS Motion	Sales reaches out after 14 days of inactivity. Misses peak intent. CAC payback: 24+ months.	PQL fires on high-intent signal: pricing page 3x in 7 days, 5 teammates invited, free tier ceiling hit. SDR outreach within 4 hours. CAC payback: <9 months.
Integration Ecosystem	2–3 native integrations. Zapier added when users ask. No partner ecosystem strategy.	Integration marketplace with 100+ partners, each a distribution channel. Notion: 150+. HubSpot App Marketplace: 1,400+. Each integration gets its own GTM plan.
Trial-to-Paid	14-day trial, upgrade button in corner, 1 reminder email. Converts at 3–5%.	Reverse trial: everyone starts on paid, downgrades after 14 days if no upgrade. Loss aversion drives 15–

AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
		25% conversion. Usage-based nudges, not calendar nudges.
NRR Optimization	Annual renewals managed manually. Expansion starts at Day 330. NRR: 90–105%.	Proactive seat expansion triggered by usage spike. Automated offer at 80% of usage limit. Quarterly business reviews for accounts >\$10K. NRR: 120–140%.

01 Instrument the Aha Moment first. Measure time-to-first-core-action for new signups. Median TTAha >5 min means fixing this beats any acquisition experiment.

02 Build integrations before users know they need them. Slack's GitHub + Jira + Google Drive integrations made Slack stickier. Each reduces substitutability by one competitor.

03 Engineer the PQL alert like a fire alarm. Best SDRs respond to PQL pings within 4 hours. Route PQLs to your top 20% performers only. Never let high-intent signals age.

04 Price at the point of value realization. Charge per seat, per usage unit, per output — never for access alone. Slack: per active user. AWS: per GB. Loom: per video. Align pricing with felt ROI.

05 The template gallery is the growth engine. Notion's 1M+ community templates are free acquisition. Every template page ranks on Google. Every shared template creates a signup. Enable power users to build and share.

06 Developer advocacy is B2B word of mouth. Great docs, CLI tools, and code samples turn developers into external advocates. Linear, Stripe, Supabase built half their growth via developers who didn't work for them.

DEEP CASE STUDY

Figma: From Design Tool to \$20B Category Creator

Figma entered a market dominated by Adobe and Sketch and won with four master moves. **Browser-native:** Every other design tool was desktop-only. Figma worked in the browser — a share link let anyone view in real time, turning every design file into a live demo. **Real-time collaboration:** Google Docs had normalized collaborative editing; Figma brought it to design, making the product essential for reviews, stakeholder feedback, and developer handoffs. **Free tier for students:** Figma seeded 500+ universities. Students graduated and brought it into their companies. Enterprise conversations started with "we're already using this." **FigJam + plugins:** Expansion to whiteboarding + plugin marketplace made Figma the platform for design workflows. Adobe's \$20B acquisition offer (blocked by regulators) confirmed the platform valuation.

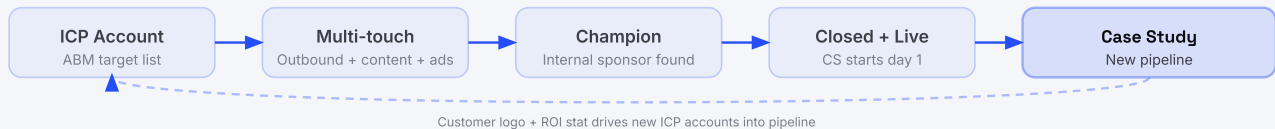
Master move: Didn't fight Adobe's distribution — bypassed it by going browser-native and seeding through individual designers who had no purchasing power but enormous influence over their employers' tool decisions.

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B2B / Enterprise

SLG + ABM

B2B ENTERPRISE GROWTH LOOP



AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Outbound	Mail-merge with {FirstName} and {Company}. Same cold email to 1,000 contacts. 1–2% reply rate. SDRs spend 70% on sequences.	Clay enrichment: pulls recent LinkedIn post, company news, tech stack, hiring signals to generate 1 specific observation per prospect. Reply rates 8–15%. SDRs spend 70% on calls, not research.
ABM Selection	ICP = "mid-market SaaS." 300 accounts with identical treatment, selected by headcount from ZoomInfo.	Tier 1 (30 accounts): white-glove, custom research, exec outreach. Tier 2 (150): programmatic ABM. Tier 3 (1,000): inbound. Tier 1 criteria: funded last 6 months + tech stack signal + 50–500 employees.
Champion Enablement	Delivers 40-slide deck for champion to forward. Champion can't explain ROI. Deal dies in committee.	Champion toolkit: (1) 1-page exec summary with company-specific ROI numbers, (2) comparison vs. status quo, (3) "How to present to CFO" talking points, (4) reference customer at a similar company willing to take a call.
Customer Success	CS checks in at 30/60/90 days. Renewal conversation at Day 330. No expansion motion. NRR: 95%.	CS monitors usage continuously. Expansion triggered by usage signals, not calendar. QBRs with exec sponsor, not just champion. Proactive risk flag when usage drops 20% WoW. NRR: 120–130%.
Case Studies	"We helped CompanyX improve efficiency." Vague, generic, published 6 months after the win.	"How CompanyX cut pipeline time from 14 days to 3 hours, saving \$840K." Published in 30 days. 5 formats: 1-pager, long-form, slide, video testimonial, quote card. Used in outbound for same vertical.
Competitive Intel	Sales team guesses at objections. No battlecard. Loses 30% of deals to competitors never anticipated.	Win/loss analysis quarterly. Battlecard per competitor updated monthly. When Competitor X is mentioned: 3 objection responses, 2 switch

AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
		customers, 1 comparison table. Wins 60%+ of competitive deals.

01 The CFO is always in the room. Every champion justifies spend to finance. Build ROI calculators that auto-generate a 1-page financial summary: payback period, productivity gain, cost of doing nothing. Champions will use it without being asked.

02 Trigger-based outreach beats cadence-based 5:1. Don't reach out on "Day 1 of sequence." Reach out when they raise a Series B, post a job your product replaces, or their competitor just became your customer.

03 Best CS reps don't sell — they surface value. Train CS to ask: "Since implementing X, what else has become a problem?" The next contract expands itself when asked at the right moment.

04 Certify implementation partners. For products requiring significant setup, certify consultants who sell implementation and refer software. Salesforce's partner ecosystem generates 70%+ of revenue. Start building yours at 50 customers.

05 Mutual action plans close deals 40% faster. After every demo: co-write a doc showing who does what by when. Gong data: deals with a MAP close 40% faster. Mutual commitment eliminates ghosting.

06 G2 reviews compound like SEO. A G2 category leader appears in every research process before a sales call. Run quarterly G2 campaigns: email best customers, 2 clicks to review, gift card as thank-you. 200+ reviews in 6 months is achievable.

DEEP CASE STUDY

Gong: Revenue Intelligence Category Creation

Gong didn't sell a "sales tool" — they created the "Revenue Intelligence" category. By naming a new category, they became its default leader and defined evaluation criteria to favor their strengths. **Data flywheel:** Product improves with each conversation analyzed. More customers = better AI = better product = more customers. **Benchmark reports:** Gong publishes research using proprietary data ("What separates top 1% salespeople"). These generate earned media, establish authority, and require Gong's product to access. **Pre-suasion:** Every prospect had seen a Gong insight about their own buying behavior before the sales call. The demo was done before the AE arrived. Gong reached \$7.25B valuation in 2021 off a data-driven, thought-leadership engine with no scaled paid UA.

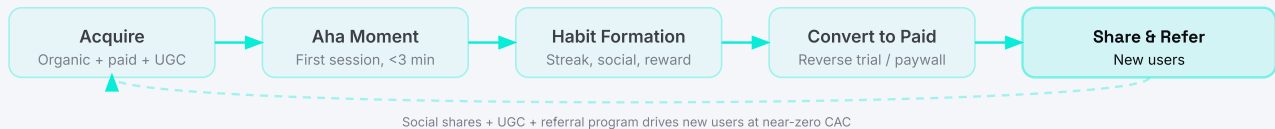
Master move: Created the category name, defined criteria to favor their strengths, published data making those criteria feel objective. Competitors were forced to fight on Gong's turf.

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B2C Consumer Apps

PLG + HABIT

B2C CONSUMER GROWTH LOOP



AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Onboarding Speed	5-step signup before seeing the product. Email verification required. Tutorial is 3 minutes long. Loses 60% before Aha Moment.	Duolingo: signup optional, first lesson starts immediately. Aha in under 3 minutes. Account creation asked after value is experienced. Registration friction near zero.
Habit Loop	Generic "come back" push at 9am. No personalization. Opened 2–3% of the time. Ignored after week 2.	Push sent at exact time user historically opens the app. Content personalized to streak state. Duolingo's owl turns red when streak is at risk — anxiety, not just reminder. Opens at 15–20%.
TikTok / Social	Reposts Instagram content to TikTok. 3,000 views. No creator partnerships. No comment strategy.	Duolingo hires a dedicated TikTok creator. "Unhinged Duo owl" persona is distinct from all other channels. Videos answer real TikTok search queries. 7M+ followers. Viral moments monthly.
Referral Design	"Give \$10, get \$10" buried in settings. Discovered by 0.5% of users. Zero incremental acquisition.	Referral embedded in product moments. Strava: sharing a run creates a beautiful Instagram Stories card — the share IS the product. Wordle: colored grid shares are the entire distribution model. 10M+ daily actives, zero paid marketing.
Paywall Timing	Paywall at signup. User hasn't experienced value. 98% close it. Revenue per install: \$0.20.	Paywall at moment of highest desire: after failing a premium feature, hitting streak milestone, seeing behind the lock. Duolingo: paywall when user runs out of hearts mid-lesson. Conversion 5× higher. Revenue per install: \$1.20+.
Shareable UGC	Testimonials collected annually. Staged photos. No UGC strategy. Relies entirely on paid ads.	Spotify Wrapped, Wordle grid, MyFitnessPal streak badge — outputs users share because they reflect

AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
		personally on the user. The shareable output IS the marketing. UGC drives 30%+ of new installs.

01 Onboarding friction destroys revenue. Every extra field costs users who would have paid. Measure drop-off at each step. >20% drop between any two steps = that step is broken. Cut until you can't.

02 TikTok is a search engine, not a broadcast channel. Search "how to learn Spanish" on TikTok — millions of results with purchase intent. Post 3 search-optimized videos per week for 90 days before judging results.

03 The streak is loss aversion, not reward. A 50-day Duolingo streak motivates because users are terrified of losing 50 days, not because they want 51. Design mechanics that make users afraid of stopping.

04 UGC hooks: achievement, comparison, transformation. Spotify Wrapped (achievement). BeReal (authentic moment). "6 months on Hinge" (transformation). Engineer the shareable output, not just the share button.

05 D1 retention is the only metric that matters in weeks 1–8. If D1 <30%, nothing compounds. D1 is fixed in onboarding. Fix onboarding before touching any other metric.

06 Variable rewards retain better than fixed. Slot machines beat vending machines for engagement. Duolingo's gem amounts are variable. Build randomness into reward signals (within ethical limits).

DEEP CASE STUDY

Duolingo: 10M to 500M Users Without Scaled Paid UA

Duolingo grew from 10M to 500M registered users without a traditional paid UA budget. **Streak mechanics:** The streak creates loss aversion that brings 40M daily actives back every 24 hours. The streak freeze (paying to protect a streak) was one of their highest-converting in-app purchases — users buying relief from anxiety, not a feature. **TikTok:** Zaria Parvez was given creative freedom to portray Duo as unhinged and obsessive. The account hit 1M followers in 9 months. Each viral video worth millions in equivalent ad spend. **Shareability:** Every achievement generates a shareable card. Users share because it reflects on them personally, not because Duolingo incentivizes it. 30%+ of new installs are organic shares. **Freemium as distribution:** Only 7% of users pay, but the 93% on free generate data to improve AI, social proof for marketing, and organic referrals. The free tier is the distribution engine.

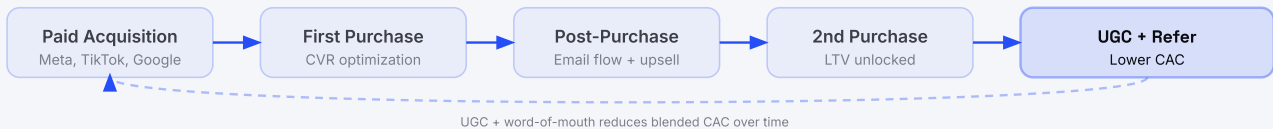
Master move: Built streak anxiety that generates more daily usage than any notification strategy, then made that usage visible and shareable so power users market the product for free.

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E-Commerce

DTC + RETENTION

E-COMMERCE GROWTH LOOP



KEY DIFFERENTIATOR – 12-MONTH CUSTOMER LTV MULTIPLIER

Mediocre operator		1.2× first order
Master operator		3–5× first order

AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Email / SMS Automation	Welcome email + abandoned cart email. 2 flows total. Klaviyo open rate 18%. Revenue from email: 10% of total.	20+ behavioral Klaviyo flows: welcome, browse abandon, cart abandon, post-purchase (D1, D7, D30), win-back (D60, D90, D180), VIP tier upgrade, birthday, back-in-stock, replenishment. Email drives 30–40% of total revenue.
Post-Purchase Sequence	Order confirmation email + shipping update. No revenue extraction after purchase. Waits for the customer to come back on their own.	Day 0: order confirmation + "while you wait" cross-sell. Day 3: shipping update + how-to content. Day 7: review request + photo request for UGC. Day 14: complementary product email. Day 30: loyalty program invite + "you might be running low" replenishment nudge.
Paid Creative Strategy	Runs 2–3 ad creatives per campaign. Scales budget on creative before it's proven. Kills creatives based on "I don't like it" not data. ROAS: 1.5–2.5x.	Tests 20–30 creative concepts per month with structured hypothesis (format × hook × audience). Kill threshold: \$50 spend with <1% CTR. Scale threshold: profitable at \$500 spend. Top 20% of creatives generate 80% of revenue. Creative lab is a continuous production machine. ROAS: 3–5x.

AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Subscription / LTV	One-time purchase default. Subscription available but not promoted. Customer LTV after 12 months: 1.2x first-order value.	Subscription as default option, presented before one-time purchase. Subscriber-exclusive products and pricing. Cancel flow that offers pause, discount, or swap instead of immediate cancel. LTV after 12 months: 3–5x first-order value.
Attribution	Runs on Meta/Google platform attribution. Sees Meta ROAS at 4x, Google at 3x, assumes combined performance is great. Scales both. Actual blended ROAS: 1.8x.	Triple Whale or Northbeam for multi-touch attribution. Knows true blended CAC across all channels. Media mix modeling for channels without pixel (podcast, OOH, influencer). Makes budget decisions on actual payback, not platform-reported ROAS.
UGC Strategy	Sends 5 PR packages to influencers. Waits for them to post. Gets 2 posts. No usage rights acquired. Can't run as paid ads.	UGC brief to 50+ micro-creators monthly. 2 deliverables each (raw video + photo). Full usage rights acquired for 12 months. 80% used directly as paid ad creative. UGC integrated into PDPs (product pages) alongside professional photography. Average UGC ad outperforms studio creative 2.5x on CTR.

01 The second purchase is more valuable than the first. Customers who make a second purchase within 90 days have 4–5x the LTV of single-purchase customers. Build your entire post-purchase sequence around engineering that second transaction.

02 Platform ROAS is a lie. Meta reports ROAS on the last click before purchase. It claims credit for customers who were already going to buy. Triple Whale / Northbeam shows you what actually drove the decision. Most brands find their true blended ROAS is 30–50% lower than platform reporting.

03 UGC brief quality determines creative quality. Vague brief = vague content. Give creators: the exact hook to use, the problem to show, the product benefit to demonstrate, and examples of content that has worked before. UGC is a production process, not a hope-and-pray exercise.

04 Win-back sequences are the highest-ROI email you can send. Lapsed customers (no purchase in 90+ days) who re-engage are 3x more likely to become long-term buyers than new customers. A 3-email win-back sequence with a 15% discount and urgency recovers 8–15% of lapsed base.

05 Subscription default increases attach rate 3–5x. Default the purchase option to "Subscribe and Save" with monthly delivery. Most customers accept the default. The ones who actively choose one-time are fine — you've already maximized subscription attach rate on those who didn't decide.

06 Your review collection timing is wrong. Don't ask for a review at Day 1 (product hasn't arrived). Don't ask at Day 3 (first impression only). Ask at Day 14 — the customer has used the product enough to have an informed opinion, and still has the positive new-purchase feeling.

Gymshark: From Bedroom Brand to \$1.3B via Community + Creator

Gymshark was founded in 2012 by Ben Francis, a 19-year-old operating out of a garage. By 2020 they were valued at \$1.3B. The entire growth engine was community and creator-led, with zero traditional retail distribution until years after launch. **Creator strategy:** Ben Francis identified 6 fitness YouTubers with dedicated audiences who weren't yet sponsoring fitness brands and sent them free kits. He didn't ask for posts. He just said "wear it if you like it." The organic posts generated Gymshark's first viral wave. By 2016 they had 50+ "Gymshark Athletes" who were genuine community members, not paid models. **Gymshark pop-ups:** Rather than opening stores, Gymshark ran pop-up "meet your athlete" events where fans could meet their favorite creators. These events generated UGC, sold out product, and built real-world community bonds. **Limited drops:** Seasonal limited-edition collections with countdown timers created genuine scarcity. Drop days saw website traffic spikes that crashed servers — free PR that amplified the next drop's hype. **Community as product feedback:** Gymshark ran private Facebook groups for their athlete community. Product feedback was real-time and genuine. New colorways and styles were community-influenced before launch.

Master move: Treated creators as community members, not billboards. Gave them product they genuinely wanted, let them post organically, and let the authenticity create trust that paid ads can never replicate.

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Professional Services

REFERRAL + REPUTATION

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES GROWTH LOOP



AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Positioning	"We help businesses grow." Full-service agency. Generalist. Competes on price. Can't charge premium. Interchangeable with 100 others.	Hyper-specialized: "We help Series A SaaS companies in fintech get their first 100 enterprise customers." Premium pricing because they're the only expert in that exact problem. April Dunford's principle: the riches are in the niches.
Proprietary Framework	Delivers work via generic project management. No named methodology. Clients can't remember or recommend what was done because it has no name.	Named proprietary framework. McKinsey 7S. BCG Matrix. GTM Partners' "Go-to-Market Fit" Model. The framework IS the brand. Clients can say "they use the X Method." The framework becomes a hiring signal ("do you know the X Method?"), which compounds reputation.
Case Studies	"We helped Company X with their marketing." Vague results. Client is the vendor. No client quote on the outcome.	Client-hero narrative: "CompanyX's CMO Sarah Chen explains how they achieved 3x pipeline in 6 months." Client is the protagonist. Firm is the guide. Includes specific metrics, named individuals, and challenges overcome. Published as 1,500-word article + 60-second video.
Referral System	"If you know anyone who needs our help, let us know." Asked at end of every engagement. Gets 0–1 referrals per year.	Structured referral ask at the exact moment of peak client delight (when a major milestone is hit). Provide 3 specific profiles of ideal clients so the referral conversation is easy. Follow up with "who in your network runs a company like [specific example]?" Referral introductions get 50%+ close rate.

AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Thought Leadership	Posts "thought leadership" articles that are actually product brochures. Writes about their services. Gets 10 views per article.	Publishes research, data, or opinion that the target buyer finds genuinely valuable — whether or not they ever hire. EY, Deloitte, McKinsey publish reports that CFOs read because the data is useful, not because they want to buy consulting. The research creates a reason to be in the same conversation.
Network Leverage	Attends 3 industry conferences per year. Has a booth. Collects business cards. Gets 1–2 leads per event. ROI unclear.	Speaks at conferences instead of exhibiting. Speaking = authority signal + 45-minute pitch to the entire audience. Hosts intimate dinners for 10 target buyers at the same conference. 10x better networking ROI than a booth. Investment: speaker training + 2 hours of dinner per event.

01 Niche down until it hurts, then niche down more. "We help SaaS companies" is too broad. "We help B2B SaaS companies with 10–50 person sales teams close their first enterprise deal" is a category. Be the only option, not the best option among many.

02 Name your methodology. Unnamed work is forgettable. "We did a strategic review" gets no referrals. "We ran our Revenue Acceleration Sprint" gets passed around. The name is a referral handle. Invent it today if you don't have one.

03 The referral ask has a timing problem. Asking at the end of an engagement is too late — the emotional peak has passed. Ask 2 weeks after the client's biggest win. That's when they're most enthusiastic and most likely to advocate.

04 Publish one insight per week, not one article per quarter. LinkedIn rewards consistent posting with distribution. One 200-word insight per week from the firm's principals builds more audience in 6 months than one 2,000-word article per quarter.

05 Anchor pricing on value, not hours. "This engagement will increase your pipeline by \$2M. Our fee is \$50K." That's a 40x ROI conversation. "We charge \$250/hour for 200 hours" is a cost conversation. Reframe all proposals to value-based pricing immediately.

06 The best salespeople in professional services are past clients. A 30-minute reference call from a happy past client closes more deals than a 3-hour sales process. Invest in keeping past clients happy even after the engagement ends — quarterly check-ins, sending relevant articles. They are your sales team.

DEEP CASE STUDY

McKinsey: How a Consulting Firm Built an Unassailable Brand Moat

McKinsey is one of the world's most recognized brand names in B2B despite spending essentially nothing on traditional advertising. Their entire brand was built on three compounding assets.

Framework ownership: McKinsey's 7S Framework, GE-McKinsey Matrix, and "Three Horizons of

Innovation" are taught in business schools globally. Every MBA who learns the framework thinks of McKinsey when they need strategy consulting. The educational content IS the sales funnel. **Alumni network effect:** McKinsey alumni become CEOs, CFOs, and board members at major companies — and then hire McKinsey. The investment in training junior consultants to an impossibly high standard creates clients 10–20 years later. **Publishing as positioning:** McKinsey Quarterly publishes research that CFOs and CEOs actually want to read. The research is free. The audience is every C-suite buyer in the world. The byline does the selling. McKinsey has never needed a sales team because their intellectual output arrives in buyers' inboxes before any sales conversation starts.

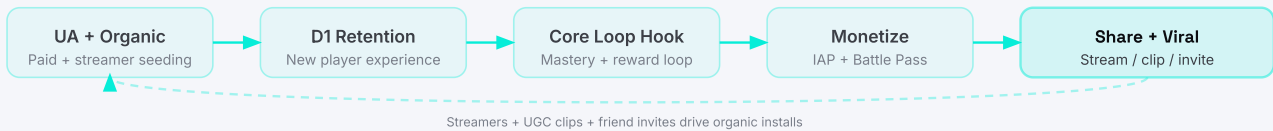
Master move: Invested in creating intellectual property (frameworks, research) that is genuinely useful to their buyers, who then associate McKinsey with the quality of the thinking before any engagement begins. The IP is the marketing budget.

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Gaming

D1 RETENTION + LIVE OPS

GAMING GROWTH LOOP



AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Pre-Launch Seeding	Sends a press release to gaming journalists 1 week before launch. Gets 2 reviews. Posts a launch trailer on YouTube. Launch day downloads: 5,000.	Identifies 10–20 micro-streamers (10K–100K audience) in the game's genre 3 months before launch. Seeds early access + exclusive content rights. Each creates authentic gameplay content before anyone else. Combined reach: 1M+ pre-launch. Launch day downloads: 100,000+.
D1 Retention	Tutorial is the same for all players regardless of device, playstyle, or prior gaming experience. D1 retention: 20–25%. No dedicated new player team. D7 falls off a cliff.	Dedicated "new player experience" team with D1 as their single KPI. Tutorial adapts to player behavior (slower for new gamers, faster for core gamers). D1 target: 40%+. Every D1 percentage point improvement = \$X million incremental LTV when modeled across all installs.
Live Ops Calendar	Ships content when it's ready. Seasonal events planned 2 weeks ahead. Team scrambles. Quality is inconsistent. Player engagement drops 30% in "quiet" months.	Live Ops calendar planned 3–6 months ahead. Each month has an anchor event, a mid-month event, and weekly rewards. Clash Royale, Clash of Clans, and Pokemon GO plan their event calendars a year in advance. Events are tied to real-world moments (holidays, sports events) for PR amplification.
Community Co-Development	Discord server managed by 1 community manager who posts announcements. Community feedback is read but not actioned. Players feel ignored.	Community is a co-development partner. New features are beta-tested in the Discord before release. Top community members are given "Founding Member" titles and early access. When features are shipped based on community feedback, the announcement says "you asked, we built." Players become advocates.

AREA	MEDIOCRE	MASTER
Monetization Design	Pay-to-win mechanics. Players who pay get advantages over free players. Short-term revenue spike. Long-term community destruction. Player reviews: 2.1 stars.	Battle Pass as primary monetization: time-limited, cosmetics only, available to all players at \$10. Fortnite Battle Pass generates \$1B+ annually without pay-to-win. Whale monetization through cosmetic exclusives, not power advantages. Maintains fairness = maintains community = maintains LTV.
Shareability Engineering	Share button in settings. Gets 100 organic posts per month. Game is fun but not designed to be shown to others.	Wordle: the colored grid share IS the social mechanic. Among Us: "I was the Impostor" is designed to be shared. Clip-worthy moments are engineered — spectacular fails, rare drops, PvP victories. The social content moment is a game design decision, not a marketing decision. 10M+ daily actives, zero paid UA.

01 D1 retention is the single most important metric in mobile gaming. Every 10 percentage point improvement in D1 compounds across every install you ever acquire. If D1 = 30% vs 40%, you've permanently written off 25% of your entire future LTV at scale. Fix D1 before scaling UA.

02 Seed 20 micro-streamers before seeding 1 macro-streamer. A micro-streamer (20K followers) who loves your game will post 10 videos per month for 3 months. A mega-streamer (5M followers) will post once. The micro volume wins.

03 The Live Ops calendar is a growth strategy, not a content schedule. Plan events around real-world cultural moments (holidays, sports finals, viral trends). Clash of Clans saw 40% DAU spikes during seasonal events. The event is a re-acquisition mechanism for lapsed players.

04 Design one "clip moment" per session. Ask: "What would a player want to post to TikTok / Twitch today?" If the answer is "nothing," your session loop needs work. Spectacular failure moments, rare drops, and surprise reveals are all clip-worthy by design.

05 Battle Pass economics beat IAP economics. A \$10 Battle Pass generates more revenue than a \$10 IAP purchase because it creates a 30-60 day engagement commitment alongside the revenue. Players who buy the Battle Pass play 2-3x more. More play = more social sharing = more organic UA.

06 The best community managers are former players, not PR people. Hire from the community. Community members who become staff have authentic credibility that no PR hire can replicate. They know what the players care about before they have to ask.

DEEP CASE STUDY

Among Us: Accidental Viral + Intentional Retention

Among Us was released in 2018 by a 3-person studio called InnerSloth. It got 30–50 daily players for 2 years. In August 2020, two Twitch streamers — Sodapoppin and xQc — started playing it to fill dead time during a stream. Within 48 hours, it had 500,000 concurrent players. The studio had not changed the game. The product was the same. What changed was a single distribution event. InnerSloth's response is the masterclass. **No monetization panic:** They did not rush to add pay-to-win mechanics or flood the game with ads to capitalize on the spike. They invested in servers to handle the load first. **Cosmetics monetization:** They released cosmetic DLC packs at \$3–\$5 each. No impact on gameplay fairness. Players bought because they loved the community, not because they needed an advantage. **Community feedback loop:** They added colorblind mode, reported bugs the community flagged, and communicated transparently about their small team's capacity. The honesty built loyalty. **The result:** Among Us reached 100M+ downloads and 60M daily active users at peak. The total paid marketing budget during the viral period: \$0.

Master move: When a viral spike hits, serve the existing community first — don't exploit them. InnerSloth's restraint preserved community trust, which converted a viral spike into a sustained player base.

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Master Tools Appendix

The canonical tool stack across all 21 growth domains. Organized by function so you can build or audit a complete growth stack.

DOMAIN	CATEGORY	PRIMARY TOOLS	AI / AGENT LAYER
PMF Measurement	Survey + Analytics	Typeform, Delighted, Google Forms	Claude for synthesis, ChatGPT for sentiment
Positioning	Research	Wynter (message testing), Wynter B2B panel, SparkToro	Perplexity for competitive landscape, Claude for framework application
Metrics & Analytics	Product Analytics	Mixpanel, Amplitude, PostHog (open source), Heap	Mixpanel AI, Amplitude AI insights
Founder Brand	Social + Scheduling	Buffer, Hypefury, Taplio (LinkedIn), Tweet Hunter	Claude for drafts, Taplio AI for LinkedIn optimization
PR / Storytelling	Media outreach	Muckrack, Cision, Featured.com, HARO	Claude for pitch drafts
SEO	Research + Content	Ahrefs, Semrush, Clearscope, SurferSEO	Surfer AI, MarketMuse, Clearscope AI
GEO (AI Search)	LLM Optimization	Profound, Goodie AI, Otterly.ai	Claude for schema markup generation
TikTok / Social Search	Content creation	CapCut, Descript, Opus Clip	Opus Clip AI (auto-clips), ElevenLabs (voiceover)
KOL / Influencer	Discovery + Mgmt	Creator.co, Grin, Aspire, Modash	Modash AI for vetting, Claude for brief writing
Paid Acquisition	Ad Platforms	Meta Ads, Google UAC, Apple Search Ads, TikTok Ads	Madgicx, Motion (creative analytics), Pencil (AI creative)
Attribution	MTA / MMM	Triple Whale, Northbeam, Rockerbox	Triple Whale Moby (AI attribution)

DOMAIN	CATEGORY	PRIMARY TOOLS	AI / AGENT LAYER
CRO	Experimentation	VWO, Optimizely, AB Tasty, Google Optimize	Intellimize (AI personalization)
Email / CRM	Marketing Automation	Klaviyo (e-com), Customer.io (SaaS), HubSpot, Braze	Klaviyo AI, Braze AI, Jasper for copy
Retention / Onboarding	In-app & engagement	Appcues, Intercom, Chameleon, Userpilot	Intercom AI (Fin), Gainsight Einstein
Mobile / ASO	App Store Optimization	Sensor Tower, AppTweak, MobileAction, StoreMaven	Sensor Tower AI, AppTweak AI
Mobile Monetization	Subscription Management	RevenueCat, Adapty, Apphud	RevenueCat Paywalls AI
B2B Outbound	Sales Prospecting	Apollo.io, Clay, ZoomInfo, Lusha, Instantly	Clay AI enrichment, 11x AI SDR, Artisan
CRM / Sales	Pipeline Management	Salesforce, HubSpot, Attio, Folk	Salesforce Einstein, HubSpot AI, Gong AI
Community	Community Platforms	Discord, Circle, Slack, Discourse, Lu.ma	Common Room (AI member insights), Orbit
Partnerships	Partner Management	PartnerStack, Impact, Crossbeam, Reveal	Crossbeam AI (account overlap)
Fundraising	Investor Relations	Affinity CRM, Docsend, Carta, Crunchbase, PitchBook	Affinity AI, Docsend AI (engagement tracking)

	SAAS	B2B ENT	B2C	E-COMM	PRO SVC	GAMING
Product Analytics	core to stack	medium	core to stack	medium	low	core to stack
Email / CRM Automation	medium	medium	medium	core to stack	low	low
Paid Acquisition	low	low	core to stack	core to stack	low	core to stack
Attribution & MTA	low	medium	medium	core to stack	minimal	medium
Community Platforms	medium	medium	medium	low	low	core to stack
Creator / UGC / KOL	low	minimal	core to stack	core to stack	low	medium
Sales / CRM Pipeline	medium	core to stack	low	low	core to stack	minimal
	minimal	low	medium	core to stack		

Illustrative tool-category centrality by client type — for calibrating which stack layers to prioritize when scoping a new engagement.



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